# The Coffin Lid Closes

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# The Coffin Lid Closes

by Lunaeryi


Summary

Phainon thought he had it handled. A world-class detective thought otherwise. Tension snaps, walls get redecorated, and the night ends in legal blackmail dressed like a love confession. Somewhere between flight and fight, Phainon finds himself choosing option three: bitter, reluctant applause.

Moral of the story: If you're going to stalk someone, make sure they aren't better at it.


Notes

I'm dead. Dying even. That trailer was not for the faint of heart.

Holy shit I am so sorry I just realized a day later to add this, CONTAINS SPOILERS FOR PHAINON'S LEAKED NAME

See the end of the work for more notes

The room smelled of copper.

It clung to the air in thick, metallic strands, seeping into the walls, into his skin, settling at the back of Phainon’s throat like rust. The flickering bulb overhead buzzed in its corroded fixture, casting sickly yellow light that shimmered against damp, cracked concrete.

His hands wouldn’t stop shaking.

He hadn’t noticed when they’d started. He wasn’t sure they ever hadn’t. The stickiness between his fingers was tacky now, drying in the humid basement air, painting his skin in smears of red that looked black in the dim light.

On the floor, the body was no longer a person.

Just a shape. A heap of limbs twisted in unnatural angles, flesh swollen and purpled, split lips drooling blood down onto the floor. One of the eyes hung half-lidded in its socket, lid puffed fat with bruising. A tooth gleamed several feet away, like a tiny pale stone in a pool of rust.

Phainon stared at it.

He should have felt something by now. Panic, maybe. Or horror. Revulsion. That sick, clenching lurch in the gut he’d always imagined he’d feel, faced with this.

But there was nothing.

Only a coldness, distant and creeping—like his bones had been scooped hollow and filled with frost.

A wet sound burbled from the shape.

Phainon’s gaze flicked up, slow as oil.

It was still alive.

Somehow, the thing on the floor was trying to move. A hand reached toward him, the fingers bent and broken, slick with blood. It trembled as it stretched, grasping not for a weapon, not to strike—but as though it sought him. Some last tether to the idea of kindness in this world.

“I… I told you…”

The voice was moist. Thick with blood, every word gurgling from a throat clogged with ruin. A trembling, rasping defiance.

“You’ll… you’ll never be free of this…”

The hand clawed at the air between them.

“Someone… someone’s gonna find you… even if it takes years… they’ll see you… in your dreams… in the glass… they’ll find you, you sick little f__”

The hammer came down.

Once.

The bone cracked with a sick, damp snap. Blood sprayed up the wall in a single, arterial arc.

Twice.

The voice cut out. The lips kept moving for a heartbeat longer, working at some final word.

A third time.

The skull gave. A thick, splintering sound. Something soft and gray slid from the split, smearing across the floor in a sluggish spill.

Again. And again. And again.

Until there was nothing left but a pulp of meat and bone, unrecognizable as anything that had once spoken. The hammer dropped from his hand,

clattering against the floor in the quiet that followed.

Phainon stood there for a long moment. His chest was tight. His throat burned. His face felt wet—sweat, or tears, or blood. He couldn’t tell anymore.

Slowly, his eyes lowered to the body. To what remained of it.

There, tangled around the remains of its neck, was a chain. A small, tarnished silver necklace with a glass bead charm, cheap and cloudy with age.

It was stupid. Insignificant.

He crouched and took it anyway, fingers trembling as they closed around the cold metal.

The basement light flickered once, then steadied.

And in the silence, Phainon could still hear the voice.

Could still feel the words sinking into him like rusted hooks.

*They’ll find you.*

And in the end, someone did.

Ten years later.

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The interrogation room wasn’t what it used to be.

No flickering lights, no cracked plaster or rusted vents bleeding rust stains down the walls. The new station was glass and chrome—clean lines, cool lighting, the air carrying that faint chemical sharpness of fresh paint and sterilized surfaces. It felt less like a place to confess your sins and more like a surgical theater, built for cutting people open without ever laying a hand on them.

Phainon sat at the small metal table, perfectly composed. His legs crossed at the knee, fingertips brushing idly along the cuff of his tailored sleeve. The chair beneath him was molded plastic, stiff and angular in the way meant to wear a person down after an hour. He wore it like a throne.

Across from him, Mydei flipped through a slim folder with steady, unhurried hands.

There was no small talk. No introductions. No need. They both knew who the other was.

Phainon had followed his work long before this. Before the man's return to the city—what the press politely labeled a special assignment. Official statements were as dry and unrevealing as expected, but anyone worth their salt knew better. You didn't pull a man like Mydei back for small-town turf wars or mid-level racketeering.

Three dismantled crime syndicates in under a year. High-profile disappearances. Entire networks gutted and left hanging, their assets seized in meticulously timed raids, their internal rot dragged into daylight. The kind of precision work that made internal affairs sweat because it left no one to bribe, no loopholes to exploit. A record like that didn't get you promoted. It made you dangerous.

And then, without fanfare, he was gone.

The official line said "transferred overseas." The more honest whispers suggested other possibilities. That certain powerful people—the kind who didn't like waiting to find out whose door the detective might knock on next—had moved him like a chess piece. Out of reach. Out of sight.

But here he was again.

Temporary, supposedly.

Phainon didn't believe in temporary. And he didn't believe in coincidence.

He’d studied Mydei’s face for years. In press photos, in surveillance stills, sometimes grainy captures on crime scene footage. A phantom in human form, always a step outside the spotlight, always half in shadow. The kind of man who left others to speculate, to build myths around him because he offered them nothing real to hold onto.

In person, the effect was worse.

Mydei didn’t posture. He didn’t need to. There was a cold clarity to him that stripped away pretense, a discipline that made other men look like amateurs pretending at authority. It was a kind of brutal efficiency Phainon had seen in men who knew precisely how much force it took to stop a heart and when it was worth the trouble.

And against all better judgement, Phainon adored every second of it.

Not just the danger, though that was part of it. Not just the thrill of sitting across from the one man in the world most likely to see through him. It was the sheer, unflinching irony of the thing. The rare pleasure of being in the presence of someone who didn’t fumble, or fill the silence with empty noise.

Mydei was exactly what the stories said.

And worse.

Phainon watched the detective’s hands as they turned a page. Long fingers, calloused at the knuckles, nails neatly kept.

“Phainon,” Mydei said at last, voice leveled.

He didn’t ask how Phainon was, or if he wanted a drink, or why he was there.

It wasn’t that kind of room.

It wasn’t that kind of man.

Phainon smiled, slow and easy, leaning back in his chair. “Detective.”

That was the game, then.

Two men seated at a table, each waiting for the other to blink.

And Phainon, despite everything, was looking forward to it.

He let his mouth quirk in a polite smile. “I have to say,” Phainon murmured, “I wasn’t expecting to be personally questioned by the agency’s crown jewel.”

No response.

Predictable.

Mydei slid a photograph across the table.

A woman—fair-haired, her face half obscured by numbered scene markers, blood gone black against the asphalt. The flash had caught the glint of a bracelet, one slender wrist bent at an unnatural angle.

“Where were you between nine and midnight two nights ago?” Mydei asked.

Phainon leaned back slightly, giving the question a beat of false consideration.

“At the office,” he said, pleasantly. “Late audit.”

Mydei’s eyes didn’t lift from the file. “Your assistant clocked out at eight. Building logs show no activity after 10:30.”

Of course they did.

“Still there,” Phainon replied. “I prefer working alone.”

A notation.

Phainon let his gaze drift—not openly, but enough to take in the man opposite him. The unflinching stillness of someone accustomed to

occupying tight, silent rooms. Clean-lined suit, no visible weapon, though Phainon didn't doubt it was there. Nothing soft about him. Not his hands, not his mouth, nothing.

He wondered, absently, what it would take to make him bleed.

"You knew her?" Mydei asked, tapping the photo once.

"I remember her at the gala," Phainon replied, giving the image a cursory glance. "Didn't catch a name."

"You left together."

A brow arched. Feigned surprise, executed with just enough subtlety to pass. "Did we?"

"Eyewitness put you both in the parking structure at eleven."

Phainon gave a mild, almost apologetic smile. "A bit late for a gala, isn't it?"

"Not answering the question."

The correction landed soft as a scalpel, and Phainon let it linger.

"My mistake," he said, adjusting his cuff. "I left around 10:30. Alone."

A pause followed. Not long, not awkward—just long enough for the discrepancy to hang between them like a thread, waiting to be tugged.

Then Mydei slid another sheet across the table. Security log. Neat timestamp. Phainon's own signature in ink too crisp to deny.

"Your signature logs you out at 10:30," Mydei said. "But building exit sensors recorded no activity on the main floor until 11:07."

Phainon didn't flinch.

"I was working in the conference room."

Another page turned.

“Motion detectors were offline for scheduled maintenance.”

A soft, thoughtful hum. “I did notice the lights flickering.”

Next—a transaction slip. Offshore account. Numbers tidy, transfer timestamped four hours before the victim’s estimated time of death.

And there it was.

The line, drawn in careful ink.

Mydei tapped the paper once with the back of his pen. “Funny thing about offshore accounts. They tend to belong to people with something to hide.”

Phainon leaned in, elbows resting lightly against the table’s edge.

“I invest in overseas logistics,” he replied. “High-risk, high-yield. Not a crime, Detective.”

“The deposit came in the same night she died.”

Phainon let a slow breath slip through his teeth, pretending to consider the implication.

Then, as if the absurdity of it had just struck him, he chuckled.

“Honestly,” he said, voice low, conspiratorial, “I’m flattered you think I’d kill someone over five grand.”

A flicker.

Not much—the barest twitch at the corner of Mydei’s brow. But it was there.

Phainon’s pulse sharpened.

“Humor me,” Mydei said. Voice like frost through glass. “Where were you between eleven and midnight?”

Phainon sighed, the long-suffering sort meant to dismiss tension. “Drinking,” he answered. “Private club. Old friend back in town. Messy divorce, poor bastard. Figured he could use a good pour.”

He drew a receipt from his inner pocket—slim, pre-folded. Set it on the table with two fingers. Mydei took it without pause, eyes scanning the print.

“Witness?”

“Two,” Phainon said, savoring it. “And the bartender.”

Three false witnesses. One gone. Two paid. The footage looped on a flaw in the surveillance system, old as sin and just as effective.

Mydei knew it.

He wouldn’t say, but Phainon could feel the recognition in the room. The shift from clinical inquiry to something colder. The kind of quiet, predatory attention that left lesser men sweating.

It looked good on him.

Phainon licked his lips, tasting the tension.

“I should thank you,” he said, leaning just a little closer. “You’ve no idea how tedious business conferences are by comparison.”

For the first time, Mydei’s gaze lifted.

No amusement.

But not indifferent.

That was what made him dangerous.

Most men cracked. Some postured. Mydei simply watched.

Phainon smiled, slow and razor-bright.

*I could carve that expression into stone. Hang it in my bedroom. Name it.*

The silence stretched, coiled, until finally—Mydei exhaled through his nose, pushed the paperwork back across the table.

“For now,” he said, rising.

Phainon tilted his head. “Leaving so soon?”

Mydei spoke without turning.

“Enjoy your drink, sir.”

And then he was gone, the door hissing quietly shut behind him.

Phainon stretched his arms back, grinning up at the ceiling.

*He knows.*

*And he can’t touch me.*

Not yet.

Perfect.

He reached for the folder Mydei had left behind, brushing fingertips across the cool surface.

Cutest little detective I’ve ever seen.

This was going to be *fun*.

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The low hum of servers. Rain against glass. A faint trace of cedar polish in the air.

Phainon sat behind his desk, watching numbers scroll lazily across his monitor—stock fluctuations, reports, figures he could shift with a handful of keystrokes.

He wasn’t looking at any of it.

Some old jazz tune hummed under his breath, half-remembered from a bar in Singapore. He didn’t know the words anymore, just the bones of the melody.

He was waiting.

Right on cue: the muffled slam of the outer doors followed by the clipped, unhurried rhythm of shoes against tile and the distant, startled murmur of Hyacine at reception.

Phainon smiled. Slow. Unbothered.

A knock, perfunctory.

“Come in.”

The door opened.

Mydeimos stepped inside like the place belonged to him. His coat damp at the shoulders, a paper cup of coffee in one hand. Tailored charcoal jacket, dark slacks, collar sharp. Hair still neat despite the rain.

He didn’t wait for an invitation. Crossed the room in three strides and dropped into the chair opposite the desk.

“Detective,” Phainon greeted, warmth in his voice.

Then, as if remembering to make it look like this wasn’t expected,

“Everything alright? What brings you by?”

Mydei’s gaze lingered a second too long before drifting to the desk, the monitor, the room.

“Just passing through,” he said, voice smooth, unhurried.

Took a sip of his coffee like he wasn’t here for a reason.

The door cracked open behind them. Hyacine, polite smile on her face, clearly uncertain whether to stay.

“Sorry—I wasn’t sure if—”

Phainon gave her a small, reassuring wave.

“It’s fine, Hyacine. Take the rest of the afternoon. I’ve got this.”

A slight hesitation. A careful nod toward Mydei. Then she slipped out, the door closing softly behind her.

A beat of silence.

Phainon leaned back in his chair, steepling his fingers.

“She’s new to the city. Not used to surprise visits.”

Mydei set his coffee down, studying him with that same unreadable calm.

“Your friend at the club seemed a little jumpy earlier,” he said, voice light. Casual, if you weren’t listening too closely.

Phainon’s expression didn’t shift.

“Pardon?”

But he knew what this was.

Reliable sources had already tipped him off.

The good detective, chasing threads. Calling witnesses at odd hours. Cross-referencing statements for hairline fractures. Slipping one of them a doctored security reel to see who’d fold first.

Mydei didn’t blink.

“The manager. Kept looking at the cameras while he swore you were a reliable man.”

Phainon let out a soft, almost amused breath.

“I tend to leave an impression.”

Mydei made a sound in his throat—neither agreement nor contradiction. Took another drink.

Then, as if it were idle conversation,

“Funny thing about power outages,” he murmured, gaze shifting to the rain-lashed skyline. “Whole block around that club lost grid access for seventeen minutes. The night of the incident.”

Didn’t look at him when he said it.

Phainon’s pulse stayed even.

“I heard,” he replied. “Lucky timing. Traffic’s hell when the lights go out.”

He tapped a few keys on the monitor, a meaningless flicker of numbers.

Mydei took his time.

“You’d be surprised how often outages overlap with cell tower blackouts.”

And there it was.

Geo-fencing. He was tracing signals.

Phainon knew because he’d made sure of it. Had slipped that breadcrumb just visible enough for Mydei to find, just sharp enough to draw blood when he grabbed hold.

Delicious.

Phainon smiled to himself.

“You always this thorough,” he asked, looking up, “or am I special?”

Their eyes met.

“Let’s say you’re good for business.”

Phainon’s grin widened.

For a moment, neither spoke. Just sat in that quiet, coiled space where the real conversation hung somewhere unsaid between them.

Then—with the most casual motion imaginable—Phainon reached across the desk, lifted Mydei’s coffee, and took a long, deliberate sip.

“Oops.”

A flicker at the corner of Mydei’s eye. Barely there.

“Keep it,” he said flatly, rising.

From inside his coat, he produced a folded magazine. Set it on the desk. An article visible in bold print:

> **Crackdown on Offshore Laundering: High-Profile Businesses Under Fire.**

Dog-eared. Because of course it was.

Phainon’s fingertips brushed the page.

Mydei turned for the door.

He was almost through when Phainon spoke.

“Detective.”

A pause in the doorway.

Phainon’s smile softened. Just a touch.

“Actually had a question for you.”

Mydei tilted his head, considering.

Phainon gestured toward the empty chair.

“Got a minute?”

A pause.

Then—the barest curve of a smirk at the corner of Mydei’s mouth.

He stepped back inside and shut the door.

Phainon leaned back in his chair, the folded magazine balanced between his fingers, the ink smudging faintly where his thumb rested against the page.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Then—as though they were simply old acquaintances making small talk—Phainon spoke.

“You know,” he began, “I’ve been meaning to ask. What brought you back?”

It was phrased lightly, but there was force behind it.

Mydei gave him a look, one brow lifting in quiet skepticism. The kind of look that suggested he was deciding whether the question deserved an answer.

They both knew the story already. How the city had shipped him off in the hopes of silencing a problem, only to have him return ten times worse. Interpol consults. Private sector manhunts that made international news. A trail of dismantled crime syndicates in places polite society pretended didn’t exist.

They’d turned him into a legend.

Phainon expected a noncommittal answer. Some polished line about temporary assignments or departmental need.

But to his surprise, Mydei didn’t deflect.

He tapped his fingers once, a soft rhythm against the desk’s surface. Then, after a brief pause, spoke.

“There was something about this one,” Mydei said. “Details I’d seen before.”

Phainon’s gaze sharpened.

“Before?”

Mydei gave a small nod.

“Long time ago. Back before I was on the force. I was nineteen, maybe. Volunteering under a detective I knew. Helping sort files, chase dead-end statements. The usual pointless work they throw at eager kids.”

A faint, almost self-deprecating smile ghosted at the corner of his mouth.

“Thought I wanted to be a doctor back then.”

Phainon let out a soft, genuine laugh.

“You? A doctor?”

“I wasn’t very good at taking orders,” Mydei admitted, that faint smile lingering for just a second before his expression cooled, gaze shifting to the window, then back.

“But there was one case,” he continued. “A body down by the docks. Middle of the night, no cameras. Storm coming in off the bay. Mutilated bad.”

Phainon didn’t interrupt.

“The face was gone. Blunt force trauma. Symbols cut into the inner arms—not obvious, you’d have to know where to look. Missing a finger. Lock of hair gone. No ID. No one claimed her.”

Phainon watched him, intrigued despite himself.

“And it stuck with you.”

Mydei’s gaze didn’t waver.

“It didn’t make sense. Too many details for a random killing. Everything about it was meant to mislead—the staging, the weapon choice, even the timing. The detective in charge wrote it off as a drifter gone mad. Open-and-shut.”

His voice dropped.

“But I didn’t buy it.”

Another pause.

“I spent months after that, quietly pulling records. Reading every hospital log, death report, missing persons file I could get my hands on. Never found another quite like it.”

Phainon’s pulse remained steady, though something beneath his ribs gave a slow, unfamiliar turn.

“How long ago was this?” he asked.

Mydei didn’t look away.

“Ten years.”

The words landed between them like an anvil.

Phainon let out a low breath, a half-whistle.

“Ten years is a long time to chase a ghost.”

“Some things don’t leave you,” Mydei said softly.

He drained the last of his coffee (that he stole back), set the empty cup down with a quiet click. For a moment, it seemed like that was all—until he added, almost as an afterthought:

“That women from the gala. Same cut pattern, same missing finger. Burn marks this time, though—a small patch of hair, scorched clean. Not like before. Progress, maybe.”

Phainon smiled, easy as sunlight.

“Well,” he murmured, “you’ve always had an eye for detail.”

Mydei stood.

He moved to the door, hand resting on the handle.

He lingered there, just long enough to feel deliberate.

“See you around, Phainon.”

Phainon’s voice was a low hum, almost fond.

“Wouldn’t miss it.”

The door clicked softly behind him.

For a while, Phainon remained seated, gaze settling on the empty coffee cup, then on the magazine still in his hand.

He hadn’t expected that story. Not from him.

He thought, foolishly, that he’d already mapped out every corner of this man.

A slow grin tugged at his mouth.

*God, he was beautiful when he talked about dead bodies.*

Outside, the rain deepened, streaking the glass in thick silver lines.

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The opera house had been beautiful once—a sanctuary built for glass-shattering sopranos and velvet-gloved applause, for pale hands tossing roses from balconies and hearts breaking beneath crystal chandeliers.

Now, it belonged to a quieter kind of predator.

Candlelight shimmered from a hundred overhead fixtures, the warm flicker softened by the slow, spiraling haze of cigar smoke and murmured old money accents. High, arched ceilings glimmered with fading gilt, their age showing in hairline cracks the restoration hadn't quite erased. Crimson velvet drapery pooled like spilled wine against dark mahogany walls, and the air held the layered scent of aged paper, expensive perfume, and something metallic and sour beneath it all.

A string quartet played in the far corner—a somber, antique piece chosen less for beauty than for the affectation of those who liked to pretend they appreciated classical things.

Phainon arrived early.

As he always did.

He stepped from the car into the rain-damp evening beneath a discreet valet's umbrella, handing off a single black leather glove and drawing the invitation from his inner pocket.

Name on the card: Lucien Virelle.

One of a half-dozen aliases, each carefully maintained, their financial arteries still comfortably bleeding.

His mask was sleek black, polished to a lacquered shine, with long, narrow oryx horns curling subtly back from the temples. Not ostentatious. The kind

of thing an old house in Marseille might've passed down through generations of discreetly bloodstained heirs.

Inside, the floor was already half filled.

Men in tailored evening coats and bespoke shoes. Women in silk so fine it caught the light like mist. Masks of Venetian glass, carved bone, and ancient motifs—the desperate, eternal habit of the rich and criminally inclined to dress themselves as gods.

Phainon moved through them with easy, unhurried grace. A glass of deep red wine in one hand, a polite, disinterested smile curving his mouth.

The air buzzed with half-whispered scandal, old grievances wrapped in civility.

*"Duval's still bedding Fontaine's wife. Has for eight years. Fontaine knows. Lets it happen."*

*"That's not her real hair. Had the original scalp in my desk drawer for three months."*

*"LeClair's portrait is a forgery. Saw the original burn in a safehouse south of Marseille, spring before last. They never check the brushstrokes."*

Phainon's inner commentary drifted alongside the murmurs, half amusement, half ritual inventory. A lifetime of rooms like this, of paper-thin civility stretched over bone.

And if anyone noticed the tension threading through his shoulders tonight, no one dared name it.

Because tonight, buried among the jade opium pipes, smuggled Fabergé eggs, colonial pistols traded like old sins, and war relics dressed up as nostalgia—Lot #43 waited.

An unremarkable antique locket.

To the catalog, a Victorian mourning piece, valued modestly for age and provenance.

To him—a problem.

He’d given it to a woman three months ago, at another charity gala beneath chandeliers, not unlike these. Fastened it around her throat with a charming smile in front of half the city’s elite.

Hours later, she was cooling in a hotel bathroom, throat opened to bone.

His people had handled it. The body. The evidence. The security feeds.

The locket.

Or so they’d claimed.

And yet—here it was.

He’d already dealt with the men responsible. Their replacements. The replacements’ families. Buried it so deep it should’ve stayed dead.

Its reappearance meant only one thing:

Someone was watching.

Phainon wasn’t the kind to leave loose ends.

And so, here he was.

Another eccentric patron among wolves, waiting to quietly reclaim what should never have resurfaced.

The quartet shifted to a darker, minor key.

Phainon’s wine tilted lazily between his fingers as the auctioneer—a narrow-shouldered man in a gold half-mask, his voice brittle with old European education—took the stage. The murmurs hushed, save for the occasional low cough, the clink of a glass.

The bidding would start soon.

He made a final, polite circuit through the crowd, cataloging the faces. The Czech smuggler with the limp. The sharp-eyed buyer from Dubai with a taste for human teeth. The art fence who tried to pass off a fake Rothko last year.

All of them amateurs.

Theater costumes stretched over nervous, hungry men.

Phainon glanced again at the catalog.

**Lot #43. Estimated time: 11:35 PM.**

Almost time.

He smiled, teeth catching the candlelight behind the mask.

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One by one, the relics of other people's violence made their descent across the stage.

A bloodstained saber from a 19th-century rebellion—its blade nicked, darkened by age—went to a woman in a peacock-feathered mask for the price of a modest villa.

A Roman signet ring, rumored to carry a curse was claimed by a syndicate heir from Prague with a careless flick of his gloved fingers.

Then a smuggled oil painting, pried from the ruins of a chateau during the collapse of '44, passed from one indifferent owner to the next.

Phainon watched with the sort of idle detachment one might afford an aging marionette show.

He raised his hand twice—once for a grotesque modern sculpture shaped like a screaming man's head, bought purely for the private joke of it, and

once for a heavy antique compass likely pried from the wrist of a man long drowned.

He knew how to play this room.

Never too eager. Never too disinterested.

Here, he was Lucien Virelle—eccentric collector, patron of the dying arts, a man with the polished detachment of old money and older appetites.

And while his face betrayed nothing, the old, familiar tally was running in his mind.

The man three seats down in the sapphire mask—he'd buried two bodies for him in Portugal.

The woman in the fox-fur wrap at the bar—her brother's ruin sealed by a ledger no one officially knew existed.

The dealer whispering to the auctioneer now—a coward, but one who could be useful when his price was met.

He kept score the way some men counted cards.

The auction carried on.

Lot #31. Lot #32.

The string quartet slipped into a minor-key prelude, the notes thin and glassy in the air. Candlelight pooled and guttered, reflecting off polished brass and the soft sheen of silk. Somewhere behind him, a cough broke the hush.

It was nothing.

A room like this—half of them had weak lungs, the other half smoked as though it might delay whatever waited for them in the grave.

And yet—something edged into the periphery of his awareness.

A quiet wrongness. The sensation of a weight shifting in a room, the subtle change in the way voices carried, how shadows stretched.

Phainon’s brow furrowed, faintly.

Nothing overt.

He took another sip of wine—dry, good, expected—and waited for the feeling to resolve.

Another item crossed the stage.

A trinket this time, some hideous porcelain figurine. He paid it no mind, but out of habit let his gaze drift toward the back rows to watch the bidding.

And then he saw him.

Half-obscured behind a cluster of financiers leaning in over their catalogues.

At first, just another figure in a mask.

A lion.

Not one of the gaudy, sunburst monstrosities these old-money relics favored. No—this was sleeker. Carved brass, the mane a pattern of etched, subdued lines. The face expressionless, the suggestion of fangs where the light caught.

The man wore a dark suit. The collar of his shirt left slightly open, exposing skin to the candlelight.

Speaking, casually, to a weapons dealer’s wife.

And that was the first wrong thing.

Because she wore a goat mask. And she hadn’t left her husband’s side at one of these auctions in seven years. Phainon recognized her by the scar

just visible above her collarbone—a detail most people wouldn’t notice, but then again , he made a point of knowing.

The second thing was the wine.

Mydei didn’t drink wine.

Hadn’t for as long as Phainon had known him.

Claimed it dulled his sense of smell, made his head feel slow. Always water or, when he could get away with it, coffee.

And yet here he was.

Phainon’s chest went tight, a cold kind of dread working its way into the marrow of his bones. His hand flexed faintly against the stem of his glass.

Their eyes met.

A beat.

Then another.

The man in the lion mask lifted his glass in a slow, deliberate toast. A curl of a smirk visible—restrained, unhurried, entirely intentional.

Damn it.

The words slid through Phainon’s teeth in silence, his pulse tightening.

He hadn’t known.

Hadn’t expected it.

Not here. Not tonight.

And that—more than the fact of Mydei’s presence—was what truly bothered him.

Because Phainon was meticulous.

The guest list had been acquired, cross-referenced, dissected. His people had eyes on every entrance, every vehicle logged against the underground registry. No one slipped past those nets.

No one.

Except, apparently, the one man who wasn't supposed to.

Of course.

And worse than that—worse than the audacity—was the way he sat there. Half-reclined. At ease in a room thick with blood and money, the candlelight catching the sharp line of his jaw, the easy sprawl of his posture as though he belonged to it.

And God help him—it made Phainon's throat go dry.

A subtle heat prickled at the back of his neck.

*Damn it.*

The sharp strike of the gavel snapped him back.

Lot #36.

Phainon forced his gaze away.

His fingers flexed beneath the tablecloth.

Focus.

Later.

There was still a locket to claim.

And the night—its shape had changed.

It took the better part of half an hour for the auction to settle into its quieter phase. The early spenders had either slipped away to private rooms or lounged at the edges, half-listening, half-dreaming.

Phainon had long since eased into his rhythm, wine glass balanced against his knee, indulging a portly gentleman in an owl mask with idle conversation about the slow death of true craftsmanship in modern forgery.

But he was waiting.

And at last, the moment arrived.

The auctioneer cleared his throat.

“Lot Forty-Three,” he announced. “An 18th-century French heirloom. Silver locket, recovered from a private estate in the Loire. Provenance unconfirmed.”

A slim, velvet-lined tray was brought forward. The locket caught a single thread of candlelight, throwing a thin gleam into the heavy air.

It was small. Oval. Faintly tarnished, with a delicate etching at the clasp. Ordinary to anyone else’s eye.

Phainon didn’t move, save to raise his paddle.

“Twenty thousand.”

The bid was expected. A few disinterested murmurs passed between guests. No one here was in the market for keepsakes.

Then a voice—not loud, but sharp enough to split the quiet.

“Fifty thousand.”

Phainon’s stomach tightened, a cold, sinking twist. His gaze slid toward the sound.

The lion mask.

Mydei.

Relaxed as ever in his chair, one arm slung over the backrest, the wine glass untouched beside him. The faintest curl at the corner of his mouth—that same insufferable, unreadable amusement.

A soft click of Phainon's tongue against his teeth.

Son of a bitch.

The auctioneer barely hesitated. "Fifty thousand, acknowledged."

Phainon let a breath escape through his nose. Amusement coiled faintly at the edge of his irritation.

"Sixty," he murmured.

Mydei shifted, a lazy tilt of his elbow against the chair.

"Seventy."

Phainon's paddle lifted. "Eighty."

The room quieted. Brokers glanced up, more curious than concerned. The locket wasn't worth the numbers climbing around it, and neither man bidding for it was a familiar name in these circles.

Curiosity bred attention.

For a moment, Phainon entertained the idea of letting him have it. Letting him walk out with the thing, unaware of what string it might unravel.

But no.

Too dangerous.

It was a trail meant for no one's feet but his, and if Mydei stumbled into it, he'd tear the whole damn road apart before letting it lead him anywhere.

So he raised.

Again.

Eighty became ninety.

Then a hundred.

A low ripple of murmurs spread. The locket's estimate had been twenty-five. Now it hovered at four times that, and neither man seemed inclined to relent.

Phainon's jaw flexed.

Then Mydei spoke.

"Three hundred thousand."

A beat of silence. Heavy. Thick.

Even the auctioneer faltered, gavel paused in midair.

Phainon's fingers froze halfway to his glass. He blinked—not at the number, but at what it meant. It wasn't an offer. It was a message, wrapped in silk and dropped at his feet.

Too high to pursue without notice.

Too sharp a move for anyone not watching.

He'd built a life on not being remembered. Not like this.

A muscle ticked at his jaw. His lips twitched, though whether in humor or frustration he couldn't have said.

And then he let it go.

The gavel came down with a clean, decisive knock.

“Sold.”

Polite applause followed—scattered and perfunctory.

Phainon lifted his glass, smiling without warmth, toasting to no one at all.

The auction moved on.

And while fortunes changed hands, while ancient weapons and bloodstained artifacts passed from monster to monster, Phainon sat still. His posture easy, his pulse steady. The tension buried too deep to show.

Until a light touch found his shoulder.

Hyacine.

A moth mask tonight, pink hair wound neat. She leaned in, her voice a soft thread meant for him alone.

“It’s done. Zurich proxy filed at seven-thirty-eight. Auction master’s verifying now. Lot Forty-Three’s marked as pre-sold. Clerical error.”

Phainon’s mouth twitched.

“Good work.”

She smiled, bright and pleased, then vanished back into the folds of the crowd.

Five minutes later, a discreet announcement murmured through the room.

“Ladies and gentlemen—an addendum. Lot Forty-Three’s sale has been retracted due to a prior claim. Our apologies to the bidder.”

A faint ripple of indifference passed over the gathered audience.

The locket was gone.

Phainon eased back in his chair, letting himself savor the warm gleam of candlelight on crystal and gold.

And though he didn’t look, he felt it—the weight of Mydei’s stare, steady and unblinking from across the room.

Let him watch.

The night was far from finished.

---

As the auction dwindled, the room began to unravel itself.

The serious buyers took their leave first—their business here was transactional, not recreational. A few lingered out of obligation, sipping aged digestifs and talking about upcoming affairs in Vienna, Prague, and private island collections no one would ever admit to.

The younger patrons, the leeches and thrill-chasers, drifted toward the lounges. There were still vices left to sample before the sun returned.

Phainon stayed.

He wasn’t eager to step into the cold just yet. His nerves, though expertly masked, hummed with a residual tension. A performance held too long left its mark.

He refilled his glass, though he hardly drank it.

Phainon caught flashes of the lion mask between conversation circles and scattered clusters of the curious. That easy confidence, the way a wolf might linger amid lesser predators, entirely at ease because it knows how the night will end.

The sight of it frayed something in him.

He focused instead on the retrieval.

A word to one of the senior staff—an older man with discreet ink at his throat, markings that promised old debts and older loyalties. The man bowed, muttered, *"This way, sir,"* and led him from the main floor.

The corridors beyond the auction hall were lined in velvet and hush. Crystal sconces threw soft light against dark wood, catching on the edges of gilt-framed horrors.

They passed private vaults and reinforced display rooms: ancient coins, forbidden manuscripts, a wall of long-dead birds caught forever in mid-flight.

Phainon scarcely glanced at them.

At last, the attendant stopped before a domed chamber lined in midnight velvet. A single glass case stood at its center.

The locket waited inside.

Phainon dismissed the man with a flick of his hand.

Alone now, the room seemed to press closer.

He stepped forward, the soft hush of his shoes swallowed by thick carpet. The locket sat against its velvet bed, catching the low light like a drop of quicksilver. Small. Unassuming. A child's keepsake in the cradle of old horrors.

He might have smiled, had his stomach not felt so cold.

The lock on the case yielded beneath his touch.

He took the locket, letting the chain spill between his fingers, the metal cool and fine as spun wire.

And then he noticed it.

Not immediately, but a slow, prickling unease.

A faint smear at the clasp.

Barely there. Invisible to anyone without reason to look. But there. The kind of mark no cautious attendant would leave. It was too deliberate in its carelessness. A thumbprint blurred just so.

A message.

His fingers faltered.

The locket slipped through them, struck the velvet base with a soft, treacherous clink.

He didn’t move. Not yet.

A voice drifted from the doorway, uncertain. *“Sir?”*

Phainon didn’t answer.

He stared down at the locket, his mind folding quickly around the shape of the thing. If this had been a simple theft, it would be gone. No one in this place could have stopped it.

Which meant it was never about taking.

It was about being seen.

A demonstration.

Not the crime itself—but the fact that it could have happened, at any moment, without warning.

The proof left behind like a lover’s mark on a collarbone.

And there was only one person here capable of that kind of trespass. The only one bold enough to get that close without a whisper of detection, arrogant enough to leave a touch meant for him alone, and clever enough to know exactly what it would do when Phainon found it.

His jaw tightened, a sharp twitch at the corner of his mouth.

Not a name.

Just *him*.

And the understanding slid into place like a blade between ribs—how badly, how dangerously, he'd underestimated the man.

Not a scavenger in a wolf's coat.

A wolf. Smiling all along.

He drew a steady breath, rolled his shoulders, and retrieved the locket. The chain felt warmer now, as though it had memorized every hand it had passed through.

Without another glance, he left the chamber behind.

---

The main hall had thinned to stragglers and old ghosts. Masked faces hovered near the exits, shrouded in smoke and the soft scrape of final conversations.

And passing him by, like some strolling afterthought, was the lion mask.

A casual brush of a hand against Phainon's shoulder as he passed. Light. A fraction too intimate to be innocent. Fingertips pressed in, not enough to leave a mark but enough to be remembered.

Phainon's pulse stumbled, a flicker of heat curling in low places it shouldn't.

He didn't turn, not right away.

Then the voice—low, smooth as old brandy, carrying just enough for him to catch it.

"This scene's a little decadent for you, isn't it?"

Phainon’s gaze narrowed. The words were bait, strung on a silk thread.

“Never struck me as your kind of vintage either.”

The mask turned, just enough for the light to catch along the angle of his jaw. The smile that followed had nothing wholesome in it.

“Some things are worth the indulgence.”

And then he was gone.

No lingering, final look. Just an easy, unhurried exit through gilded doors and into the night.

Phainon stood there a moment longer, the locket’s weight against his palm, the lingering press of those fingertips a phantom heat on his shoulder.

He smiled, teeth against his tongue.

It wasn’t over.

Not by a long, long shot.

---

The penthouse lay in a kind of curated hush, broken only by the low thrum of city traffic far below—a muted pulse that barely breached the thick, floor-to-ceiling glass. The lights had been dimmed hours ago, leaving the room swathed in lazy pools of amber, shadows softening into corners like lounging beasts.

Phainon sprawled in the center of the unmade bed, limbs long and careless against the tangle of silk and linen. One hand cradled a glass of something old, its rich, bruised color catching in the light. The bottle—decanted earlier, though scarcely touched—waited on the nightstand alongside a lighter and a silver dish of slim cigarillos.

He hadn’t changed. The dress shirt hung loose against his frame, top buttons undone, sleeves pushed haphazardly to the elbow. The disarray

might have scandalized half the city’s be socialites, had they been privileged enough to see him in this state.

The air smelled of aged wood, cold cologne, and the faintest trace of smoke. Somewhere distant, a clock chimed three.

His phone balanced against a bent knee, the screen aglow. Four flawless angles of a familiar space, each feeding back in crisp, perfect silence. Mydei’s latest hideaway—a modest, forgettable apartment on this side of the border, remarkable only in that no one of consequence knew he was there.

No one, except Phainon.

Of course.

On-screen, the detective moved through the kitchen, the room around him cast in a dim, golden haze. His hair, still damp from a late shower, clung in loose curls at the nape of his neck. A simple shirt, collar open, sleeves shoved to the forearm. It softened him, made him look younger, though the sharpness at the edges never dulled.

Phainon took a slow sip, the warmth of it spreading like a slow burn through his chest. He’d long since memorized every line of that apartment, every flawed lock and flickering bulb. He knew the pattern of Mydei’s fingertips on a glass, the cadence of his footsteps across uneven floorboards. There was no corner untouched by his knowledge.

And he wasn’t ashamed of it.

If anything, it *steadied* him.

He reached for the lighter. The soft click of the flame broke the hush, a brief flare of orange catching the angles of his face. The cigarillo lit with a dry whisper, smoke curling upward in a fine, silver thread. Phainon drew it in, slow and deep, savoring the taste.

A low, satisfied exhale. Almost a sigh.

It’d been too long.

The feed shimmered faintly, a minor shift in connection. On the screen, Mydei leaned back against the counter, phone in hand. The screen’s pale glow turned his face to glass, unreadable—but when Phainon exhaled another ribbon of smoke, there was a flicker.

A small tension in the jaw. The briefest tightening around the mouth.

Not enough for anyone else to notice.

But to someone who watched too closely, who cataloged every private detail with the kind of precision reserved for surgeons and killers—it wasn’t nothing.

Phainon’s mouth quirked up.

*What’s rattling you now, darling?*

He stretched, feeling the easy ache of drink-warmed limbs, then tipped the ash into the tray with a careless flick.

Then the movement on-screen pulled him back. A name flashed across the detective’s phone as the incoming call connected.

Hephaestion.

And just like that, the warmth drained from the room.

The name tasted like a bruise. Phainon had known of him for years—an old constant in Mydei’s life, loyalty that predated every careful mask the detective wore now. In private, Phainon admitted the man had been hard to track. Harder than most.

But no one stayed invisible forever.

He’d turned up a name, a face, a half-buried address, and remembered the pulse of cold irritation on seeing the man’s photograph for the first time. A face too familiar. A fixture. A threat.

On the feed, Mydei’s shoulders eased, a hand combing through his damp hair as his expression softened, the shadow of a smile touching his mouth—something unguarded and private, a thing Phainon had never seen turned his way.

The cigarillo burned bitter in his mouth.

*Should’ve brought cigarettes.*

The thought came dry, acid-edged, as he took another drag.

The distance between them, made suddenly unbearable by something as simple as a phone call.

And yet—he kept watching.

Because it was impossible not to.

Because the thought of missing even one small, telling detail was infinitely worse than the petty, gnawing jealousy curling cold in his stomach.

The call continued, Mydei’s voice low, his posture loose in a way it never was in public. Phainon marked each softened line, each private flicker of expression, committing it to the long, obsessive archive of his mind.

He would watch.

He always would.

And one day—soon—he’d see to it no one else ever could.

The ash fell soundlessly into the tray.

And the night carried on.

---

The gallery had once been a 1920s bank—all marble columns and vaulted ceilings, its heavy Art Deco ornamentation painstakingly preserved by some philanthropic heir with more money than sense. Gilded fixtures cast a

soft, honeyed glow across abstract sculptures and avant-garde paintings, the light catching on polished glassware and the faint sheen of too-tailored evening wear.

Clusters of guests milled about, lacquered and lacquer-thin, sipping wine they neither liked nor understood. Conversations hung in the air like perfumed smoke—murmurs meant more for effect than content.

Phainon slipped away from one of the main exhibition rooms, bypassing a knot of society matrons with faces pulled tight as drumskins and a financier whose most memorable feature was the high-profile disappearance Phainon had once helped discreetly facilitate. The cultivated hum of conversation trailed after him like smoke clinging to the hem of his coat.

He found a dim alcove off the corridor—unoccupied, save for a marble bust of some long-dead architect and a low leather settee that had seen better decades.

It would do.

The moment the distance between himself and the gallery's carefully staged civility closed, the public mask slipped from his face like silk from a shoulder.

Phainon leaned back against the cool marble wall with a low, exhausted groan, the kind he wouldn't allow himself in anyone's company. One hand came up to pinch the bridge of his nose, thumb pressing into the throb that had taken up residence behind his left eye.

Christ. He felt like hell.

Last night clung to him like oil—the taste of whiskey still souring the back of his throat, a ghost of smoke in his lungs. He'd woken to a migraine sharp enough to make him consider scrapping his entire day's obligations, his mouth dry and metallic, like he'd bitten down on a rusted coin.

Didn't help that he'd poured himself an extra half bottle of wine before falling asleep fully clothed, the taste of smoke and the flickering glow of

Mydei’s apartment feed the last thing his mind registered before slipping under.

Pathetic.

He’d forced down a bottle of water the moment his eyes could tolerate light, chased it with one of Hyacine’s stronger painkillers—unprescribed, naturally. It dulled the worst of it. Enough to pull on a suit, knot a tie, and show his face at this pretentious little affair.

A damn gallery.

Art critics. Minor aristocrats. Media figures desperate to be seen. The kind of brittle, painted people who couldn’t tell the difference between avant-garde and deliberate nonsense but would die before admitting it.

And yet, he’d come.

For two reasons.

One, because it was useful. Networking behind a mask of cultural sophistication, pressing hands with people whose influence didn’t require official paperwork or inconvenient questions.

And two—

Phainon let his head tip back against the marble, the cold seeping pleasantly into his skin.

His little detective.

Word had arrived that morning—Hyacine’s voice relaying the encrypted line: *“He was at the cold case archive. Downtown. Took out files from ten, twenty years back. Requested two evidence retrievals. Cross-referenced property records.”*

Of course he had.

Because someone like Mydeimos didn’t need formal clearance. Precinct favors. Old debts. Archivists who remembered what he’d done for their sister, their son, their lover, the thing they couldn’t speak of in polite company. Red tape meant nothing to him—it parted like silk beneath a knife.

Officially, a cold case stayed closed.

Unofficially, a name in the right ear, a promise in the right shade of voice, and the dead could speak again.

And Mydei could open any wound he pleased.

Without even leaving a scar.

Phainon’s mouth curved, something closer to a grimace than a smile. The migraine pressed behind his eyes, dull but insistent.

Not fear.

Not quite.

But enough to pull him from his bed, from the haze of last night’s indulgences, to trail the man here. To see how close he meant to get. To decide whether this particular game of theirs had shifted by a single, fatal square.

He scrubbed a hand down his face, feeling the cool dampness at his hairline.

A beat longer, just enough to gather what fragments of composure he still possessed, and then he straightened.

The weight of his public persona settled over him like a well-tailored coat—the easy grin, the gleam in his eye, the careless, too-rich amusement of a man untouchable by the politics of art or the sins of his company.

He adjusted his cuffs. Rolled his neck.

And strolled back into the gallery’s warm, cultivated din as though nothing had touched him.

By the time he reached the main exhibition hall, he looked like he never left.

The ache in his skull an afterthought.

But somewhere beneath the careful veneer, a thought curled and held.

*Of course you were at the archive, love.*

*Of course you were.*

---

Phainon was halfway through a conversation he couldn’t remember the start of—something about shipping routes or trade tariffs—when he felt the shift.

A presence at the edge of his awareness. Not one of the aimless socialites drifting from cluster to cluster, but someone moving with purpose.

He turned slightly, catching a glimpse of pale gold silk and the gleam of diamonds against dark hair.

“Phainon.”

The voice was low, a dusky drawl softened by wealth and old-world education. Greek by blood, if not entirely by birthplace.

Ione Thessalides.

A name passed between old families and modern tabloids alike. An heiress to a faded Hellenic title, better known for scandal-strewn affairs and a fondness for foreign champagne than for any legitimate inheritance. She was the kind of woman who survived on sharp instincts and sharper gossip.

Tonight, she wore a gown the color of old ivory, its beadwork catching the light in scattered, glinting patterns. A single diamond earring brushed the line of her throat, dark hair pinned in a loose knot.

Phainon let a smile curl at the edge of his mouth. “Miss Thessalides. I was beginning to wonder if you’d drowned yourself in a Riviera pool this year.”

She laughed, fingertips brushing against his wrist as she leaned in, a practiced intimacy.

“Tempting,” she murmured. “But I seem to have developed an inconvenient habit of surviving my vices.”

The touch lingered. A beat too long for propriety.

She spoke in proximity, in suggestion and near-contact, and Phainon—for all his problems—was fluent in that language.

“Careful,” he replied, voice dropping so only she could catch the words. “You’ll ruin my reputation.”

A smirk tugged at the corner of her mouth. “I’d be doing you a kindness.”

Her fingers ghosted along the inside of his palm, the faintest tug toward the terrace doors. An unspoken invitation.

“Perhaps we slip away. A drink. A conversation. I’ve heard you’re far more interesting when no one’s listening.”

He might’ve said yes. Let the night drift into the familiar press of skin and the dull ache of burned-out conversation, if only to bleed off the lingering edge of a migraine and the remnants of last night’s indulgence.

And then—

That particular prickle at the back of his neck. The sharp, electric sense of being watched by someone who knew how. Not a bored aristocrat or a rival broker.

Someone dangerous.

Phainon’s gaze slid past Ione’s shoulder toward the far side of the room, where a small gathering lingered near one of the more grotesque modern

installations—twisted iron, bone, and glass.

And there he was.

Mydei.

Unannounced. Uninvited. Half-length glass in hand, his posture easy, head slightly inclined toward a man Phainon half-recognized as one of those former intelligence officers now selling discretion and deniability to the highest bidder.

This time, Mydei wore a charcoal waistcoat under a dark jacket, the deep blue of his silk cravat a muted contrast against crisp white linen—expensive enough to belong, understated enough not to draw questions.

Phainon's pulse hitched, then settled into something low and ugly in his chest. That old, impossible mixture of hunger and dread.

And then, as though summoned by the weight of his attention, Mydei looked up.

Their eyes met.

No smile. No frown. Not even surprise. Just a slight, almost imperceptible tension at the line of his jaw. A narrowing of his gaze.

Recognition.

Phainon's breath stilled, the noise of the room thinning to a low, indistinct hum.

Ione's hand, still resting against his wrist, suddenly felt cloying. Her perfume too sweet. The press of silk and bodies and artfully disinterested conversation closing in like fog.

He disentangled himself gently, fingertips brushing her knuckles as he offered an easy, apologetic smile.

"Another time, love."

Ione’s gaze flicked over his shoulder, clocking the source of his distraction. She didn’t react—didn’t need to. She’d played these games long enough to recognize when the board had shifted.

A wry lift of one brow. “You always did have a type.”

Phainon’s smile sharpened, though it didn’t quite reach his eyes.

She drifted away, a sweep of pale silk and cool perfume, already seeking out safer, more predictable company.

Across the room, Mydei hadn’t moved.

Hadn’t looked away.

And in the hollow of his chest, that sick, exquisite sensation coiled tight—sharp as a needle, warm as a promise.

**Mine**.

Phainon took a slow sip of his drink, the liquor catching rough in his throat, eyes locked on the detective’s.

The game, it seemed, was very much back on.

He let his gaze linger a fraction too long before breaking from Mydei’s stare.

He turned, glass in hand, and began weaving through the gallery’s murmuring crowd—the brittle sheen of cultivated elegance.

A corner installation caught his attention.

Modern. Anatomical.

A sculpture wrought in iron and obsidian, shaped into something that might have once resembled a ribcage, if ribs bloomed outward like dissected petals. The cavity at its center suggested a missing heart. Beautiful in the way car wrecks and open wounds could be beautiful.

He stopped before it, eyes flicking over the artist's plaque though the words blurred to insignificance.

The soft shift of bodies nearby barely registered—but the prickle at his periphery did.

He didn't need to turn.

The detective appeared at his side, close enough that the lines of their shoulders nearly touched, both of them framed in the glow of gallery lights, their reflections warped in the sheen of obsidian.

Neither spoke at first.

Then—

"Curious," Phainon murmured, tilting his glass. "What passes for art these days."

A thread of dry amusement in his voice, but something else beneath it—something meant for Mydei alone.

At his side, the detective's mouth shifted. Not quite a smile.

"Says the man who's made a hobby of collecting peculiar things," Mydei returned, voice low. "Some more dangerous than others."

Phainon's chuckle was soft, a warm, hollow thing. "You wound me, detective. I've always had an appreciation for the rare and unusual."

"Appreciation isn't the word I'd use."

Another silence. The air between them felt heavier now, tension stretched taut like a string held between steady hands.

Then, almost as if continuing a thought from elsewhere, Mydei spoke.

"I expected Hephaestion tonight. But he… found other priorities."

Phainon’s mouth curved, though the motion felt brittle at its edges.

“A shame. I was curious to meet the other half of your reputation.”

Mydei’s gaze flicked to him the.

“He keeps better company than I do,” the detective said. “Tonight, at least.”

Something twisted in Phainon’s chest. Jealousy wasn’t quite the thing—too petty, too simple. It was something possessive, darker and more serrated. A gnawing, petty hunger to know precisely what those other distractions had been, and why they hadn’t been him.

He masked it behind a familiar smile. The one reserved for closing deals, for affixing signatures to things that ended with someone else’s ruin.

And then—almost absent, almost idle—Mydei’s fingers brushed his wrist.

The contact barely registered to the eye, but to Phainon it landed like a struck chord. A ghost of touch, deliberate in its casualness.

“Why don’t we find somewhere quieter,” Mydei murmured. The words were soft, conversational. But his gaze wasn’t a request.

It was a command.

Phainon arched a brow, amusement settling across his features.

“I thought you’d never ask.”

They moved together, not quite side by side, a fraction of space held between them like a live wire. A magnetic pull neither acknowledged but neither escaped.

The gallery’s hum of polite conversation and soft light receded behind them, the corners of the space growing darker, the art stranger. Where civility frayed at the edges and other kinds of games could be played.

Dangerous ones.

The heavy door swung shut behind them with a soft click.

A single lamp buzzed in the corner, casting a bruised, amber glow that spread unevenly across the walls, turning polished wood and painted canvas into shadowed impressions of themselves.

Phainon didn’t waste the moment.

He was on Mydei in a breath—pinning him back against the paneled wall, one hand settling at his waist, the other skimming up the elegant line of his throat to trace the edge of his jaw. The detective made no move to stop him.

Phainon’s mouth hovered by his ear, the ghost of a breath against skin.

“Miss me?”

Mydei gave a faint exhale, half a laugh, the corner of his mouth curving in what might’ve passed for amusement.

Phainon didn’t wait for permission.

His mouth claimed him—hard, deliberate, tasting heat and whatever perfume that clung to Mydei’s skin like a second, better-bred self. Fingers twisted into fabric. Hips pressed forwar. Mydei’s hand lifted not to repel him but to curl lightly around the back of his neck.

Their mouths found each other again, slower this time. Open, tasting, the kind of kiss meant to leave a mark beneath the skin. Between it, words traded like quiet wagers, the sort made in dark rooms over dying embers and half-empty glasses.

“Word is,” Phainon murmured, brushing his mouth along the curve of Mydei’s throat, “you’ve taken an interest in the archives.”

A statement dressed as idle curiosity.

Mydei’s lids lowered, his voice a smooth, unbothered hum. “Is that what they’re saying?”

Phainon’s hands wandered, fingers toying with the fine material at his waist, thumbs tracing idle, possessive patterns just below his belt.

He waited for a crack in his porcelain composure.

Mydei’s gaze slid sideways,a flicker of something amused there.

“You really want to know?”

Phainon’s teeth grazed his lower lip in answer.

“Indulge me.”

A sigh, more performance than exasperation, and then—one name, dropped like a stone into still water.

“Caenis.”

Phainon stilled. A tilt of the head, brow arched in feigned laziness. His pulse had already sharpened.

“Ah.” A pause, his tone light. “The councilwoman.”

Mydei shifted against him, rolling a shoulder, causing Phainon’s hand to slide lower, as though by accident.

“She had a taste for power. And secrets.”

A beat.

“She had Aglaea’s too, it seems.”

That name.

Phainon let it settle on his tongue like an old, rare wine. The corners of his mouth tugged upward.

“A pity she retired.”

The words sounded light, but they hung heavy between them.

Aglaea—the kind of woman the city still whispered about in carefully modulated tones. Empire-builder. Social darling. Beautiful, merciless, vanishing at the height of her reign into one of those polite, curated scandals no one knew of. Phainon knew. He always did.

Mydei’s lashes lowered in a long, considering blink, as though choosing what to leave unsaid.

“I’m assuming you know about her company,” he murmured.

Phainon made a faint, indulgent sound, lips brushing the line of Mydei’s jaw.

“From what I’ve seen, it’s thriving.”

A humorless quirk of Mydei’s mouth. “It was entangled in a financial scandal years ago. Buried. Caenis knew. She threatened to expose her… then vanished.”

Phainon’s hand drifted lower, smoothing over the front of Mydei’s trousers, unapologetic. His voice, when it came, was idly curious.

“So you suspected Aglaea?”

A hitch in Mydei’s breath—a subtle, delicious falter—as Phainon pressed closer, his mouth at the corner of his lips.

“No.”

And there it was.

“She adopted. Quietly. Two children. One public. A girl.”

Phainon hummed, lazy mock-interest. “Cifera.”

A small nod.

“The other…” Mydei’s voice thinned. “No trace.”

Phainon gave a soft laugh, low and intimate, like a secret shared in bed at the end of a long, cruel night.

“Even you miss a name, then.”

He leaned in, lips a hair’s breadth from Mydei’s ear, the words velvet, smoke, and the glint of a knife.

“Or would you rather I call you by your proper name, Mydeimos?”

The effect was immediate.

A pulse leapt in Mydei’s throat. His pupils darkened, breath catching in a sharp, shallow hitch.

But it wasn’t fear.

It was something better.

Phainon felt it twist in his chest—a wicked, possessive satisfaction. His fingers curled tighter at Mydei’s waist, pulling him closer, their mouths nearly brushing.

“Didn’t think I’d forgotten, did you?”

Mydei’s hand fisted in the front of Phainon’s jacket, pulling him in until their lips nearly touched, the air between them burning.

And then—a smile. Slow. Dangerous. Entirely unrepentant.

“You,” Mydei murmured, voice rough and low, “are going to be the death of me.”

Phainon smiled against his mouth, teeth sharp.

“Darling,” he whispered, voice a dark purr, “I’d be offended if it were anyone else.”

The space between them crackled. The outside world—the gallery’s subdued murmur, its champagne and curated civility—might as well have been a thousand miles away.

Here, it was only them.

And they were never polite.

He barely noticed the shift at first.

It was subtle—the way Mydei’s hand tightened around his wrist, keeping his palm where it was, warm against the narrow dip of his waist. Then, a step. Smooth, unhurried, as if adjusting for a better angle in the dim room.

But it wasn’t casual.

And Phainon knew better than to mistake gentleness for softness.

Mydei’s gaze had dropped, as though lost in thought. His thumb brushed along Phainon’s knuckles—a small, idle touch that felt too intimate for strangers, too familiar for adversaries.

Then, soft as a confession, Mydei spoke.

“I haven’t been entirely truthful with you, you know.”

Phainon let a slow smile pull at his mouth.

“Oh?” A tilt of the head. “You wound me.”

He allowed himself to be steered, the detective easing him away from the wall, bodies still close. Phainon’s fingers flexed against fabric—expensive, tailored, the kind meant for men who never intended to bleed.

“I told you,” Mydei went on, voice unhurried, “that I joined the force because of Caenis’s case.”

The name came easy now.

“I know,” Phainon murmured.

Another step.

Mydei hummed—a thoughtful, private sound.

“That wasn’t true.”

Phainon’s brow lifted by a fraction. The barest flicker of interest.

“Oh?”

Now the wall was close behind him. He could feel its presence at his back. Not yet touching—but near enough to matter.

Mydei’s eyes rose, meeting his.

“It was the year after.”

Phainon felt something cold and sweet slip through his chest. His lips parted, though no remark came. Not yet.

“The night my father was murdered.”

The words hung there, like a knife placed carefully on a table.

Phainon held the moment for a beat, then inclined his head, voice smooth.

“I’d heard you came from old money,” he said while musing. “Always wondered why you left the family business.”

A pause. Then, with a soft, practiced sympathy:

“My condolences.”

But Mydei’s mouth only quirked. A small, humorless thing.

“No need.”

Another step closer. His grip on Phainon’s wrist tightened—not enough to bruise, but enough to remind.

*Who was leading now.*

“My father,” Mydei started, voice almost affectionate, “was a monster in silk. Smiled for cameras. Killed my mother. Did you know that?”

Phainon’s stomach turned, though his face never showed it.

He hadn’t known.

And that troubled him more than it should have.

“I can’t say I did,” he answered softly. The kind of lie one tells beautifully, so it leaves no trace.

“Your secrets are better kept than most.”

At that, Mydei laughed. Quiet, genuine, and wrong.

“It was a night like this,” he went on, his gaze slipping past Phainon’s shoulder, unfocused, as if chasing some distant, bloody memory. “Dark. Rain slicked everything. I was nineteen. Wasting time chasing whatever thrill felt sharpest.”

A pause.

“When I came home, I found him dying. Blood everywhere. Staining the floors. The walls. Like something out of Caravaggio.”

Phainon’s pulse beat a sharp, jagged rhythm against his ribs, though his expression remained faintly indulgent. A man politely indulging a macabre story at a dinner party.

“And,” Mydei murmured, “I saw the one who did it.”

Phainon’s throat worked, the smallest movement.

“A silhouette,” Mydei said, his voice dipping. “Cloak. Mask. Rain rolling off his shoulders like a second skin.”

Phainon’s eye twitched.

A betraying tic.

He smothered it beneath a practiced smile.

“Did you see his face?”

Silence.

Then—a laugh.

Dark.

And Mydei’s gaze found his again, glittering with something that made Phainon’s skin feel too tight.

“Not quite,” Mydei said, and there was a softness to the words, the kind a man shouldn’t wear when recalling blood on the floor.

“But I remember one thing.”

A step.

Closer.

Chest to chest now. Phainon’s back brushed the wall.

And then Mydei leaned in—a breath’s width from his ear.

“He was beautiful.”

The whisper coiled through him, a line of heat, sharp and sickly sweet.

“If he wasn’t the most beautiful thing I’d ever seen,” Mydei breathed, “he was damn close.”

A single beat of silence.

Phainon felt something snap taut inside him.

A bead of sweat traced the nape of his neck.

And then Mydei drew back, just enough for their eyes to meet. The detective’s smile was slow, edged with something dark and intimate.

“Tell me, Phainon,” he murmured, voice like silk drawn over a blade.

“What do you think of the story?”

The room seemed to contract. The air too thick, the ceiling too low.

And for once, Phainon wasn’t certain whose hand was closing around whose throat.

For the first time in years, Phainon wanted out.

Not a retreat.

Not a calculated, wryly delivered exit.

A raw, instinctive lurch somewhere deep in his stomach telling him to *get out now* and put distance between himself and the thing wearing Mydei’s face.

He forced a brittle smile, lips too dry. “Perhaps we’re getting carried away. A breather might—”

The rest never left his mouth.

Mydei caught him by the waist and slammed him into the wall.

The force cracked the breath from his lungs, the world tilting, one rough hand at his hip and the other pinning his shoulder in place. Hard enough to bruise.

The smile Mydei gave him then was terrible.

“No more running.”

Gone was the polite mask, the cultivated civility. What stared back now was something stripped of pretense, hunger sharpened to a gleam.

Phainon flinched—a small, involuntary twitch of his frame.

And Mydei saw it.

The hand at his waist clamped down, grinding them together, bodies flush now. The press of Mydei’s thigh slid between his, firm. A pressure that made Phainon’s body arch in spite of himself.

Something hot curled low in his gut—that humiliating ache he despised, made worse by the cold satisfaction in the detective’s gaze.

Phainon opened his mouth to speak, to reclaim even a scrap of footing—but the voice that met him stripped the oxygen from the room.

“You think you’re clever?” Mydei asked, lips brushing the shell of his ear, voice faint and intimate and venomous. “One more step, and I’ll have you bent over that table with my cock so deep inside you, they’ll see my cum running down your thighs when you try to make your pretty little exit.”

A sharp, involuntary sound caught in Phainon’s throat. Not fear.

Worse.

A flicker of heat, mortification, a sick pulse of want threading through the terror.

Mydei’s mouth was on his throat a moment later, teeth biting down hard enough to mark, a bruising drag of lips and tongue. The collar of Phainon’s

shirt gave with a practiced, rough tug, buttons scattering.

Phainon gasped, head tipping back against the wall. A sound escaped him—half protest, half desperate, aching need.

Mydei pinned him fully, a knee between his thighs, angling up with excruciating precision. Phainon's hips betrayed him, grinding down for one traitorous moment before he wrenched the motion still.

A hand seized his chin, forcing his gaze upward.

"You're not leaving this room," Mydei said, "unless you're crawling."

Phainon's pulse hammered in his throat, his breath a shallow, ragged thing. He dragged in a trembling laugh, jagged and breathless.

"You're insane—"

But the words died the moment Mydei's lips brushed his ear.

"Tell me what you want, Khaslana."

It was as if the room fell silent.

As if the world itself tilted, pulled the breath from his lungs and the blood from his face.

Phainon froze.

His heart skipped once, twice—then went off-beat entirely. A low, cold sweep of horror sluiced through his veins, a sick, crawling stillness that left his skin clammy, his stomach hollow.

His name.

His real name.

Not Phainon.

Not any of the dozen aliases polished and abandoned over the years.

*That* name.

The one he'd killed for.

Buried records for.

Burned whole ledgers, witnesses, history itself to erase.

There was no possible way.

And yet.

He made a sound—something between a laugh and a choked breath, brittle as glass.

"You're bluffing," he rasped, but the words felt distant, foreign. The lie tasted weak even as it left his lips.

But Mydei was already watching him unravel, eyes darkening with slow, merciless satisfaction.

The blood had drained from Phainon's face, his body rigid even as some treacherous, humiliating part of him still ached against the pressure of Mydei's hand.

And somewhere, under the electric thrum of terror, a cruel voice whispered:

*You fool. It's over.*

Then Mydei's mouth was on his, brutal and claiming, tongue forcing past lips that barely resisted. It wasn't a kiss. It was a possession. A sealing of fate.

Phainon whimpered—actually whimpered—into it, the sound ragged and raw, shameful and hot.

The world spun, narrowed to the heat of Mydei’s mouth, the bruising grip on his waist, the wet slide of tongues and the sharp ache of teeth.

It went on, drowning him.

Until—

A knock.

“Pardon, anyone in here?”

A young woman’s voice. Bright. Oblivious.

The sound shattered the moment like glass.

Phainon’s head snapped toward the door, the world tilting violently around him. In the instant that followed, he shoved hard at Mydei’s chest.

The detective let him go. Not startled. Not angry.

Deliberate. Pleased. Like a cat slipping a paw off its prey.

Phainon staggered away, breath ragged, a hand rising to wipe his mouth, though it did nothing to erase the bruised heat there.

He didn’t speak.

Didn’t dare look back.

He crossed the room in three uneven strides, wrenched open the door.

A young woman stood there, mop in hand, eyes wide and uncertain.

He barely saw her.

“Don’t touch me,” he rasped to no one in particular, shouldering past her, the single, pounding word *runrunrun* hammering in his skull.

The girl stared after him, bewildered.

And in the dimness of the room, Mydei hadn’t moved.

He lingered in the exact place Phainon had left him. Breathing steady. Head tilted slightly, as though tasting the air.

Then, slowly, his gaze settled on the girl.

The words came soft, polite.

“Leave.”

She fled.

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Phainon didn’t remember the drive.

Couldn’t say how long he’d been sitting there, the engine humming beneath him, headlights bleaching the empty stretch of his private drive.

The city beyond the windshield blurred into indistinct shapes, glittering and indifferent. His pulse hammered against the walls of his throat, relentless, a physical thing, as though it meant to claw its way out.

His hands on the wheel were clammy.

*Khaslana*.

The name circled his skull in endless loops, the echo of Mydei’s voice scraping against the raw edge of his nerves.

He could still feel the phantom imprint of that grip around his waist, teeth at his throat, that obscene, suffocating mouth.

Phainon swallowed against the bile rising in his throat.

He fumbled his phone from his coat, didn’t bother to check the time. His thumb found the one number reserved for when every other line had been severed.

The call connected on the second ring.

“Book me a flight,” he rasped, the words spilling out in a voice he barely recognized as his own. “Now. Anywhere. Doesn’t matter.”

A sharp intake of breath on the other end.

“Wait—what happened?”

Hyacine.

Even her voice sounded too loud.

“No questions.” He braced a forearm against the steering wheel, head bowed, a cold sweat trickling down his spine. “If anyone asks, you were coerced. I threatened you. Understand? No questions. Just do it.”

“Phainon—”

He ended the call before the name finished.

The phone landed on the passenger seat, forgotten. His grip on the wheel tightened until his knuckles turned bloodless.

*Go*.

Home.

Grab what mattered.

Burn what couldn’t leave with him.

He was halfway up the winding drive before his mind caught up to his hands, headlights sweeping over the manicured hedges, the elegant facade of his estate rising out of the darkness like some ancient, disapproving thing.

The tires crunched to a stop.

The front door slammed open, rebounding off the wall.

Lights on.

No one there.

Phainon moved through the house like a man walking through a dream, his coat half off his shoulders, breath ragged, hair damp against his temples.

He didn’t pause.

Not until he reached his bedroom.

The moment the door clicked shut behind him, a storm broke loose in his chest. The veneer cracked, years of control bleeding out at the seams.

Ten years.

Ten years of absolute command.

Clean kills. Closed loops.

A web spun so fine no one had ever seen the strands.

And now it lay in ruins because of one man.

*One man.*

Phainon spun toward the closet, snatched down a go-bag.

Sidearm.

Stacks of currency.

Burner passports.

Keys to a property even Hyacine didn’t know existed.

A tie rack caught his elbow and clattered to the floor.

He swore, bent to retrieve it—then the tension snapped.

The tie rack went airborne.

Glass shattered as the mirror behind it exploded, shards scattering across the floor in a crystalline rain. The sound was too loud, sharp enough to cut straight through his skull.

His chest heaved.

Somewhere, distantly, he registered blood on his palm. He barely felt it.

Then—a sound.

Faint.

Electronic.

A soft, rhythmic pulse.

*Beep.*

*Beep.*

*Beep.*

Phainon went still.

The room contracted to a single point.

He turned his head, muscles locked, heartbeat a thick, pounding thing in his ears.

The sound came again.

A delicate electronic metronome.

Insistent. Patient.

*Beep.*

*Beep*.

He dropped into a crouch, glass crunching under his knee. His hands moved through the debris like they no longer belonged to him, driven by instinct.

And then—there.

Half-hidden behind the jagged remains of the mirror’s frame, recessed into the wall cavity.

A tiny, sleek surveillance node.

A pinpoint lens.

Its LED blinked steadily.

He stared at it.

And it stared back.

There was no breath left in his lungs, no plan. Just a crushing, suffocating weight in his chest as the world lurched sideways.

It wasn’t a fluke.

It had been there.

Watching.

Waiting.

*Mydei had been here*.

The room reeled.

He felt the laughter before he heard it.

A ragged, disbelieving chuckle that slipped out and wouldn’t stop, swelling sharp and cracked, until he was half laughing, half choking on it, pressing a bloodied palm to his face.

“You sick bastard,” he whispered, the words trembling, not with fear anymore, but awe.

Anger.

And something far, far darker than either.

Sirens.

Faint, but growing.

Then the unmistakable sound of vehicles cresting the drive—heavy, tactical. The sharp crackle of radios, the bark of terse commands.

Phainon’s blood ran ice cold.

He crept to the window, peeled back the curtain an inch.

The insignia on the convoy’s lead vehicle was unmistakable.

Hephaestion’s task force.

Elite. Uncompromising.

No mistakes. No leaks.

When they came for someone, there was no trial, no scene, no survivors.

The phone call. The apartment.

This had been in motion before tonight.

A trap.

A game.

And he’d walked, eyes open, into checkmate.

Phainon pressed his forehead against the glass, breath fogging it, a hollow, unraveling laugh slipping out.

“Played me like a fiddle,” he murmured.

And outside, the lights kept coming.

His phone buzzed against the wood of the nightstand, a single vibration cutting through the thick, suffocating quiet.

Phainon stared at it for a long, motionless moment. He already knew who it was, what it would be, and still—his hand moved, almost of its own accord, lifting the device with a steadiness he didn’t feel.

One new voicemail.

He exhaled through his teeth, thumbed it open, and let it play.

*“Phainon.”*

The way his name was spoken drew a fresh chill through the room.

*“I wonder…is your heart racing right now?”*

A beat of silence.

*“Did you truly believe you were the only one watching?”*

The voice coiled around him like silk drawn through a blade’s edge.

*“As of this evening, you are no longer a citizen. No longer a registered entity. Your accounts are frozen, your properties flagged for reclamation, your name a liability on every ledger where it once held power.”*

Another pause. The faintest sigh, as though disappointment lingered at the edges of every word.

*“But you must have known this would come. I did offer you a chance to behave, didn’t I? It seems—”* a soft, almost affectionate hum *“—you require a more personal hand.”*

Phainon leaned forward, elbows on his knees, his gaze fixed on nothing, the voice pouring through him like cold mercury.

*“So, you have a choice.”*

A tap.

*“Option one… we come through your walls like wolves. Dismantle your name, your past, your allies. The media will get its devil, the courts their trophy. It will be swift. Public. Absolute.”*

A breath—patient, expectant.

*“Or…”*

That single word lingered like a lover’s kiss against the ear.

*“You come home with me.”*

Phainon’s throat worked, breath shallow, though the room felt too still, too starved of air.

*“The courts have their language for men like you, without a name. Mental defect. Instability. A danger to yourself, to others. A man like that…”* a faint click of the tongue *“requires supervision.”*

*“They’ll call it protective custody. House arrest. But we both know better.”*

Another pause. A soft inhalation, almost a sigh.

*“I volunteered.”*

His lips parted.

*“A sealed psychiatric order. A tidy arrangement for a man who no longer exists. And because I am so very fond of you, I’ll let you keep a window view.”*

Phainon closed his eyes, pressing his thumb into his temple, the ache behind his eyes a steady, grinding throb.

And then came the final blow.

*“But make no mistake, Khaslana.”*

The name dropped like a blade, slicing through what little distance he had left to cling to.

*“You’ll never be free again.”*

The next words, when they came, were quieter. No longer a threat, but a reminder.

*“And should you entertain thoughts of running…”* a dark, almost playful curl to the voice *“I wonder how Aglaea and Cifera might endure the sudden absence of your protection. I wonder how well the world would receive the records I’ve so patiently curated on their behalf.”*

A beat.

*“I’ve kept them safe for you, you know.”* The words softened, an almost intimate fondness in them, like a hand brushing his hair back from his brow. *“All these years.”*

Then, a single, final command.

*“Decide.”*

The line cut.

The silence left in its wake was deafening.

Phainon drew a long, steady breath through his teeth. He stayed there for a while, elbows braced on his knees, the thick, suffocating quiet pressing in. Somewhere, distant but growing, the sound of footsteps began to bleed through the house—claiming the space as theirs.

Eventually, he reached for his phone, typed out three words.

**Cancel the flight.**

Sent.

The device slipped from his fingers, landing on the bedspread with a dull thud. He lifted his gaze to the fractured mirror across the room, to the tiny, glinting eye still watching him through the splintered glass.

A faint smile tugged at his mouth—brittle, bitter, something caught between defeat and reluctant admiration.

“Well played, detective.”

And beyond the walls, the night shifted—sealing itself shut around him like a coffin lid.

End Notes

Sigh, well I hope you guys at least enjoyed this in lieu of the pain

Also the last part might've been rushed, sorry abt that I didn't have time to fully beta read it =')

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!